

# Pikachu plush returns from a real space trip

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A special Pikachu **plush** toy spent 67 days aboard the International Space Station. The European Space Agency, or ESA, announced the trip on September 19, 2026.

The toy travelled to the station on April 11 in a Cygnus **cargo** spacecraft. **Cargo** means supplies or other things being carried. It returned to Earth on June 17 aboard a SpaceX Dragon **cargo** spacecraft.

While in **orbit**, Pikachu made about 1,040 trips around Earth. An **orbit** is the path an object follows around a planet or another body in space.

The journey is part of a project celebrating World Space Week 2026, which runs from October 4 to 10. An **exhibition** brings Pokémon characters together with real information about European space missions and life on the station.

The **exhibition** began in Paris in late September. It will travel to museums and other places across Europe through April 2027.

**Participating** European science and space museums will also offer special Pokémon GO activities. ESA hopes the project will encourage children and teenagers to become **curious** about space and science.

## Word Treasure

**plush** -- Made from soft, fuzzy fabric.

**cargo** -- Supplies or other things carried by a vehicle.

**orbit** -- The path an object follows around another object in space.

**exhibition** -- A collection of displays for people to visit.

**Participating** -- Taking part in an activity.

**curious** -- Wanting to learn or find out more.

## Background you need

Cargo means supplies or other things being carried.

An orbit is the path an object follows around a planet or another body in space.

## Break it down

Introduces the Pikachu plush's stay on the space station.

Explains its spacecraft journeys and trips around Earth.

Describes the World Space Week exhibition and European tour.

Ends with museum game activities and ESA's educational hope.

## Why it matters

The project connects a familiar Pokémon character with information about real space missions. ESA hopes this will encourage children and teenagers to explore space and science.

## Test what you remember

**1. Where did the Pikachu plush spend 67 days?**

- ☐ (A) ESA's headquarters on Earth
- ☐ (B) A museum in Paris
- ☐ (C) The International Space Station
- ☐ (D) A European science exhibition

**2. Which spacecraft carried the toy back to Earth?**

- ☐ (A) A SpaceX Dragon cargo spacecraft
- ☐ (B) A museum display spacecraft
- ☐ (C) A Cygnus cargo spacecraft
- ☐ (D) A Pokémon game spacecraft

**3. About how many trips around Earth did Pikachu make?**

- ☐ (A) About 440 trips
- ☐ (B) About 740 trips
- ☐ (C) About 140 trips
- ☐ (D) About 1,040 trips

**4. When does World Space Week 2026 take place?**

- ☐ (A) September 11 to 17
- ☐ (B) October 11 to 17
- ☐ (C) October 4 to 10
- ☐ (D) September 4 to 10

**5. Where did the exhibition begin?**

- ☐ (A) Rome
- ☐ (B) London
- ☐ (C) Madrid
- ☐ (D) Paris

**6. What does ESA hope children and teenagers will become curious about?**

- ☐ (A) Music and theatre
- ☐ (B) Sports and exercise
- ☐ (C) Cooking and gardening
- ☐ (D) Space and science

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: D 4: C 5: D 6: D

## Questions to think about

**MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):**